

who pretend to be there too soon can lead themselves (and others) down a potentially destructive path. But people who avoid it risk being swayed by “shiny object syndrome” whenever an influencer has a new viral financial hack.

When my husband, Travis, and I (Jen) were paying off our debt, we listened to an expert who said you should get out of debt as quickly as possible and you shouldn’t spend money on anything nonessential until you’re out of debt. It was extreme, and there were positives and negatives to living that lifestyle. On one hand, I felt miserable missing out on so many things that cost money, but on the other it forced me to get creative in meeting my “wants.” I found free ways to get what I wanted that I would’ve never thought of without the strict rule, and it taught me foundational lessons about what I value. Eventually I started listening to other teachers who were more lax on debt payoff and were, as a result, more lax on spending while paying off debt. I even listened to a few who loved debt and praised its merits. We started *Frugal Friends* to share all these new viewpoints and how we were, and weren’t, using them. As we recorded more episodes and studied more perspectives, we created our own rules for spending and found that if we wanted to spend guilt free (without sacrificing ourselves to the corporate ladder), we had to spend on what we value.

One of the reasons we think there’s so much guilt associated with spending is that most financial experts explain their methods as if they’re the best and only course of action. And anyone who deviates is doing it wrong. But we’re here to tell you that just because you follow a financial expert and respect how they spend and save, it doesn’t mean you have to practice your spending the exact same way to be successful. Improving spending is going to look different for everyone. That’s why figuring out who to learn from, how to learn it, and what’s best for you is so important.

There are a lot of places to go for financial education. Books are the number one place to start (look at you already on the right track!). It can be hard to know what teachers to trust, but a lot of work goes into a book and there are a lot of people who read it before it goes to print and review it after, so you can go into a book with a decent level of trust in what the author’s saying. Podcasts are another good place (shameless plug for *Frugal Friends Podcast!*). Are we biased? Sure. But a podcast does give you access to teachers for hours upon hours, and you can quickly decide for